

Lijphart 1999 Claude Guide

Lijphart, Arend. *Patterns of Democracy: Government Forms and Performance in Thirty-Six Countries*.

New Haven: Yale University Press, 1999.

Contents

1	Central Claims	3
2	Core Case Studies	3
3	Core Works Cited	5
4	Chapter 1: Introduction	6
5	Chapter 2: The Westminster Model of Democracy	6
6	Chapter 3: The Consensus Model of Democracy	7
7	Chapter 4: Thirty-Six Democracies	8
8	Chapter 5: Party Systems: Two-Party and Multiparty Patterns	9
9	Chapter 6: Cabinets: Concentration Versus Sharing of Executive Power	10
10	Chapter 7: Executive-Legislative Relations: Patterns of Dominance and Balance of Power	11
11	Chapter 8: Electoral Systems: Majority and Plurality Methods Versus Proportional Representation	11
12	Chapter 9: Interest Groups: Pluralism Versus Corporatism	12
13	Chapter 10: The Executives-Parties Dimension	13
14	Chapter 11: Federal and Unitary Systems	14
15	Chapter 12: Concentrated Versus Divided Legislative Power	15

16 Chapter 13: Constitutions and Constitutional Amendment	16
17 Chapter 14: Judicial Review and Central Bank Independence	17
18 Chapter 15: The Federal-Unitary Dimension	17
19 Chapter 16: The Two-Dimensional Conceptual Map of Democracy	18
20 Chapter 17: Macroeconomic Management and the Control of Violence	19
21 Chapter 18: Democracies' Policy Performance: Conclusions	20

1 Central Claims

- Democratic systems can be arrayed along two principal dimensions—the **executives-parties** dimension and the **federal-unitary** dimension—each capturing distinct modes of power-sharing versus power-concentration.
- At one pole of each dimension sits the **Westminster** (majoritarian) model, which concentrates power in a bare majority; at the other pole sits the **consensus** model, which disperses and shares power as broadly as possible.
- Lijphart identifies **ten institutional variables** (five per dimension) that operationalize this contrast, measured across a sample of 36 stable democracies from 1945–1996.
- The executives-parties dimension is defined by: (1) cabinet type (one-party majority vs. broad coalition); (2) executive dominance vs. executive-legislative balance; (3) two-party vs. multiparty systems; (4) majoritarian vs. proportional electoral systems; and (5) pluralist vs. corporatist interest groups.
- The federal-unitary dimension is defined by: (6) unitary vs. federal government; (7) unicameral vs. bicameral legislatures; (8) flexible vs. rigid constitutions; (9) parliamentary sovereignty vs. judicial review; and (10) dependent vs. independent central banks.
- Consensus democracies consistently **outperform** majoritarian democracies on most measurable policy outcomes—including macroeconomic stability, social welfare expenditure, environmental protection, women’s representation, and incarceration rates—without incurring any demonstrable cost in terms of economic growth or control of violence.
- The two dimensions are **empirically separable**: countries can score high on the executives-parties dimension (consensual) while scoring low on the federal-unitary dimension (unitary), producing a two-dimensional map that explains much of the cross-national variation in democratic institutions.
- Consensus democracy is particularly well-suited to **plural societies**—those divided by ethnic, linguistic, religious, or other deep cleavages—because power-sharing institutions reduce the stakes of electoral competition and provide structural guarantees to minorities.
- The book updates and extends Lijphart’s earlier *Democracies* (1984), expanding the sample, refining the variables, and adding the policy-performance analysis that makes the normative case for the consensus model.

2 Core Case Studies

- **United Kingdom**: The paradigmatic Westminster/majoritarian case—single-party majority cabinets, two-party competition, plurality electoral system, parliamentary sovereignty, unitary government, and weak bicameralism. Used throughout as the benchmark for the majoritarian pole.

- **New Zealand:** A second Westminster archetype, and notably a country that *converted* from a majoritarian system (first-past-the-post) to a proportional one (MMP) in 1996—providing a rare quasi-natural experiment in institutional change.
- **Switzerland:** The paradigmatic consensus case on the federal-unitary dimension—federal, strongly bicameral, rigid constitution, direct democracy provisions, and a plural linguistic/religious society managed through elite accommodation.
- **Netherlands:** The paradigmatic case on the executives-parties dimension—proportional representation, multiparty coalitions, corporatist interest groups, and a tradition of consociational elite accommodation (*verzuiling*).
- **Belgium:** A deeply divided linguistic society (Flemish/Walloon) that moved progressively from consociationalism toward federalism over the study period; used to illustrate how plural societies adapt their institutions to manage cleavages.
- **United States:** Treated as an unusual hybrid—majoritarian on the executives-parties dimension (two-party system, winner-take-all elections) but consensual on the federal-unitary dimension (federalism, strong bicameralism, judicial review, independent Federal Reserve).
- **Germany:** Another hybrid with a semi-proportional electoral system, strong federalism, and independent central bank (Bundesbank)—illustrating that the two dimensions can cut across each other.
- **Nordic countries** (Sweden, Norway, Denmark, Finland): Clustered near the consensus pole on the executives-parties dimension (PR, multiparty coalitions, corporatism) but more unitary on the federal-unitary dimension; used extensively in the performance analysis as high-performing welfare states.
- **India:** One of the few non-Western and lower-income cases included; used to examine whether consensus institutions are equally applicable in developing-country plural societies—Lijphart argues they are especially necessary there.
- **Japan:** An interesting deviant case—proportional in some respects but with a dominant-party system (LDP) over most of the study period; used to probe the limits of the institutional typology.
- **Smaller European democracies** (Austria, Luxembourg, Iceland, Malta, etc.): Used to fill out the cross-national sample and probe the relationship between country size and institutional choice.
- **Westminster former colonies** (Australia, Canada, New Zealand, Ireland): Used to examine the diffusion of Westminster institutions and the variation that emerges as they adapt—Australia and Canada both deviate from the pure Westminster model through federalism.

3 Core Works Cited

- **Arend Lijphart**, *Democracies* (1984)—the first edition of the book; *Patterns of Democracy* updates the sample, refines the variables, extends the time series, and adds the performance analysis.
- **Arend Lijphart**, “Consociational Democracy” (*World Politics*, 1969) and *Democracy in Plural Societies* (1977)—foundational earlier work developing consociationalism; the 1999 book generalizes the consociational argument into the broader consensus-democracy framework.
- **Douglas Rae**, *The Political Consequences of Electoral Laws* (1967)—the foundational quantitative study of electoral systems that Lijphart builds on in the chapter on electoral systems.
- **G. Bingham Powell**, *Elections as Instruments of Democracy* (2000) and earlier work—on the representational consequences of electoral systems; closely related comparative project.
- **Markku Laakso and Rein Taagepera**, “Effective Number of Parties” (*Comparative Political Studies*, 1979)—the Laakso-Taagepera index of the effective number of parties, which Lijphart uses throughout to measure party system fragmentation.
- **Philippe Schmitter and Gerhard Lehmbruch** (eds.), work on corporatism and interest intermediation—foundational for Lijphart’s operationalization of the pluralism-corporatism dimension.
- **Robert Dahl**, *Polyarchy* (1971)—provides the underlying conception of democracy as contestation plus participation; Lijphart’s framework presupposes Dahl’s polyarchic threshold.
- **Walter Bagehot**, *The English Constitution* (1867)—the original characterization of the Westminster system; Lijphart uses Bagehot’s description as the starting point for the Westminster ideal type.
- **Gerhard Loewenberg** and comparative legislatures literature—on bicameralism and legislative structure, used in the federal-unitary dimension chapter.
- **Alberto Alesina and Lawrence Summers**, “Central Bank Independence and Macroeconomic Performance” (*Journal of Money, Credit and Banking*, 1993)—on measuring central bank independence, used in the federal-unitary dimension.
- **Alex Inkeles and David Smith**, cross-national modernization data—among the empirical sources for the performance analysis.
- **Arend Lijphart and Bernard Grofman** (eds.), *Choosing an Electoral System* (1984)—comparative electoral systems work that feeds into the book’s electoral chapter.

- **Juan Linz** and **Alfred Stepan**, work on presidentialism vs. parliamentarism—relevant to the executive-legislative relations variable.
- **Robert Putnam**, work on institutional performance and social capital—cited in the performance chapters.
- **Pippa Norris**, comparative electoral systems and gender representation data—used in the policy-performance chapters, particularly on women’s political representation.

4 Chapter 1: Introduction

- **The central question:** Among the many forms that democracy can take, which performs best? Lijphart argues the question can be answered empirically by comparing institutional designs across stable democracies.
- **The two models:** The book’s organizing framework distinguishes two ideal types—the **Westminster** (majoritarian) model and the **consensus** model—and treats all real democracies as located in a two-dimensional space defined by these poles.
- **Majoritarianism versus power-sharing:** Majoritarian democracy concentrates power in the hands of a bare majority (or plurality); consensus democracy diffuses and shares power across as many actors as possible. Lijphart regards these as genuine design choices, not inevitable outcomes of social structure.
- **Why consensus?** The introductory case for consensus democracy rests on three claims: (1) it includes more actors in governance; (2) it protects minorities from majority tyranny; (3) it produces better policy outcomes in ways that can be measured.
- **The sample:** 36 democracies that met a polyarchic threshold for the full period 1945–1996 (or for the period since independence or democratization, whichever is shorter). Selection is explicitly on the outcome—stable democracy—to allow comparisons of institutional variation within the set of functioning democracies.
- **The time frame:** Data run from 1945 to 1996, providing roughly five decades of observations. Where possible, Lijphart uses the full period; where data are unavailable, he uses the longest available time series.
- **The plan of the book:** Part II introduces the two models; Parts III and IV analyze the ten variables on each dimension separately; Part V examines the two-dimensional map and policy performance; a conclusion draws the normative implications.

5 Chapter 2: The Westminster Model of Democracy

- **The archetype:** The Westminster model is exemplified by the United Kingdom, specifically the British system as it operated through most of the twentieth century. Lijphart

uses the UK as a reference point throughout.

- **Ten defining characteristics:** The Westminster model is characterized by: (1) concentration of executive power in single-party majority cabinets; (2) cabinet dominance over the legislature; (3) two-party system; (4) majoritarian and disproportional electoral system; (5) pluralist interest group system; (6) unitary and centralized government; (7) parliamentary sovereignty without judicial review; (8) no written constitution, or a purely flexible one; (9) unicameralism or weak bicameralism; and (10) no direct democracy provisions.
- **The logic of majoritarianism:** The Westminster model rests on a coherent theory: a clear electoral majority should produce a unified government with a mandate to govern decisively, and should then be clearly accountable to voters at the next election. Power is concentrated precisely so that accountability is clear.
- **Single-party majority cabinets:** In the UK, the winning party typically forms a cabinet alone, without coalition partners. This concentrates executive power and prevents the diffusion of accountability across multiple parties.
- **Plurality electoral systems:** First-past-the-post (FPTP) electoral rules systematically over-represent the largest party and under-represent smaller ones, manufacturing artificial majorities. This is the mechanical engine of the Westminster two-party system.
- **Parliamentary sovereignty:** The UK Parliament can pass any law without constitutional constraint; no court can strike down parliamentary legislation. This concentrates power in the parliamentary majority.
- **Limitations of the pure type:** Lijphart notes that even the UK deviates from the pure Westminster model in some respects (asymmetric bicameralism, some territorial devolution); no actual system is a perfect embodiment of the ideal type.

6 Chapter 3: The Consensus Model of Democracy

- **The archetype:** The consensus model is exemplified jointly by Switzerland and Belgium, two deeply divided plural societies that developed power-sharing institutions as a functional response to cleavage. Neither perfectly embodies the model alone; together they capture its essential features.
- **Ten defining characteristics:** The consensus model is characterized by: (1) broad multiparty coalition cabinets; (2) balance of power between executive and legislature; (3) multiparty system; (4) proportional representation; (5) corporatist interest group system; (6) federal or decentralized government; (7) strong bicameralism; (8) rigid constitution; (9) judicial review; and (10) independent central bank.
- **The logic of inclusion:** Where Westminster majoritarianism is about efficient governance by the majority, consensus democracy is about maximizing inclusion: as many

significant political actors as possible should share in governance, reducing the stakes of any single electoral defeat.

- **Broad coalition cabinets:** Coalition governments that include more parties than strictly necessary to achieve a majority are the executive expression of the consensus principle—they bring the losers into the tent rather than leaving them in permanent opposition.
- **Proportional representation:** PR electoral systems translate vote shares into seat shares with much greater fidelity than plurality systems, allowing many parties to gain legislative representation and preventing artificial manufactured majorities.
- **Corporatism:** Corporatist interest intermediation brings major organized interests (labor, business, agriculture) into structured negotiations with the government over economic policy, providing a form of functional representation beyond elections.
- **The consociational heritage:** The consensus model generalizes from Lijphart's earlier consociational democracy theory—power-sharing originally described as a specifically elite-accommodation response to plural societies is here reconceived as a general institutional design applicable to any democracy.
- **Federalism and veto points:** Federalism, strong bicameralism, judicial review, and constitutional rigidity all operate by creating veto points that prevent any single majority from acting unilaterally—they are the federal-unitary dimension's expression of the consensus principle.

7 Chapter 4: Thirty-Six Democracies

- **Sample selection criteria:** The 36 countries are selected on the basis of meeting Dahl's polyarchy threshold—adequate electoral competition, civil liberties, and participation—for a continuous period, excluding breakdowns. The sample deliberately excludes new or unstable democracies to ensure comparable institutional data.
- **Geographic and developmental diversity:** While the sample is heavily weighted toward Western Europe and the Anglo-American democracies, it includes India, Japan, Costa Rica, Israel, Botswana, and several Caribbean island states, providing some developing-world and non-Western representation.
- **The problem of small states:** Many of the included countries are very small (Malta, Iceland, Luxembourg, Barbados). Lijphart addresses whether institutional patterns differ systematically for small states and controls for size in some analyses.
- **Coding decisions:** Each country's institutional characteristics are coded on each of the ten variables for the full study period. Where institutions change over time (e.g., New Zealand's 1996 electoral reform), Lijphart averages across the period or notes the change explicitly.

- **The Polynesian and Caribbean cases:** Small island democracies (Bahamas, Barbados, Jamaica, Trinidad, Papua New Guinea) are included; most follow Westminster patterns inherited from British colonialism, providing variation on the outcomes side even while clustering on the institutional side.
- **Semi-presidential and presidential cases:** A small number of cases have semi-presidential (France) or presidential (United States, Costa Rica) systems; Lijphart argues these can still be placed on his dimensions, though executive-legislative relations require careful coding.
- **The temporal scope:** For countries entering the sample after 1945 (post-independence, post-democratization), data begin from the qualifying date. Lijphart converts all time-series measures to per-year averages to ensure comparability.

8 Chapter 5: Party Systems: Two-Party and Multiparty Patterns

- **First variable on the executives-parties dimension:** The number and relative size of political parties is the first of five variables defining the executives-parties dimension. Party system fragmentation is the most direct indicator of whether power is concentrated (two-party) or dispersed (multiparty).
- **The effective number of parties:** Lijphart uses the **Laakso-Taagepera index** of the effective number of parties (ENPP for electoral parties, ENPS for parliamentary parties) as the primary measure. This index weights parties by their vote/seat shares rather than simply counting all parties.
- **Two-party vs. multiparty:** Countries with ENPS near 2.0 (UK, USA, New Zealand pre-1996, Australia) are classified toward the Westminster/majoritarian pole; countries with ENPS of 4.0 or above (Netherlands, Belgium, Switzerland, Finland) are classified toward the consensus pole.
- **Electoral system as a cause:** Lijphart notes that electoral systems are the primary institutional determinant of party system format—Duverger’s Law predicts two-party systems under plurality rules and multiparty systems under PR—but the causal arrow runs in both directions (parties also choose electoral rules).
- **Social cleavages and party systems:** Beyond electoral rules, the number of parties reflects the number of politically salient social cleavages (class, religion, language, region). Countries with cross-cutting cleavages can sustain multiparty systems even under relatively majoritarian rules.
- **The Westminster outlier:** The UK is the paradigmatic two-party system, though Lijphart notes that the UK party system has shown signs of fragmentation (rise of the

Liberal Democrats, Scottish Nationalist Party) even over the study period—suggesting the two-party pattern is partly maintained by institutional rather than social factors.

- **Coalition formation and party number:** The connection between party number and cabinet type is strong but not mechanical—some countries with moderate multipartism produce single-party minority governments, while others with relatively few parties form coalition cabinets by convention.

9 Chapter 6: Cabinets: Concentration Versus Sharing of Executive Power

- **Second variable on the executives-parties dimension:** Cabinet type—how executive power is shared across parties—is the most direct institutional expression of the majoritarian/consensus distinction in the executive branch.
- **A typology of cabinet types:** Lijphart distinguishes: (1) **one-party majority cabinets** (classic Westminster); (2) **minimal winning coalitions** (only parties needed to secure a legislative majority); (3) **oversized coalitions** (more parties than minimally needed); (4) **minority cabinets** (single-party or coalition without a legislative majority); and (5) combinations or intermediate cases.
- **Measurement:** For each country, Lijphart calculates the percentage of the time spent under each type of cabinet over the study period, producing a continuous measure of executive power concentration.
- **Oversized coalitions as the consensus marker:** Oversized or grand coalitions—which include parties beyond the minimum needed—are the strongest institutional expression of the consensus principle in the executive branch. Switzerland’s Federal Council (including all major parties regardless of electoral results) is the limiting case.
- **Why oversized coalitions?** Oversized cabinets reduce the risk that any party excluded from government will feel sufficiently aggrieved to destabilize the system; they spread responsibility for governance; and in plural societies, they provide group guarantees to minorities.
- **Minority governments:** Minority cabinets are common in Scandinavia. Lijphart treats them as somewhat ambiguous—they are not majoritarian (one party holds power alone) in the Westminster sense, but they do concentrate executive power in a single party. Their classification depends on context.
- **The UK pattern:** The UK has one-party majority cabinets the vast majority of the time—this is the result of the plurality electoral system manufacturing artificial legislative majorities—making it the benchmark for the concentration pole.

10 Chapter 7: Executive-Legislative Relations: Patterns of Dominance and Balance of Power

- **Third variable on the executives-parties dimension:** The balance of power between the executive (cabinet) and the legislature is the third variable. Westminster systems feature executive dominance; consensus systems feature more balanced executive-legislative relations.
- **Executive dominance in Westminster systems:** In the UK, disciplined party government means the cabinet almost always commands a reliable legislative majority; the legislature effectively ratifies executive decisions rather than independently initiating or blocking legislation. The executive controls the legislative agenda.
- **Legislative balance in consensus systems:** In consensus democracies, coalition governments must negotiate across party lines; individual coalition partners retain legislative independence; and in some systems (Switzerland, the US Congress), the legislature has substantial independent power.
- **Presidentialism as a special case:** Presidential systems (USA) formally separate executive and legislative powers, producing a different kind of balance—not through coalition negotiation but through constitutionally separated institutions sharing governance. Lijphart includes these cases but notes the difference in mechanism.
- **Measurement challenges:** Executive-legislative balance is harder to operationalize than cabinet type or party number. Lijphart uses a combination of constitutional provisions, cabinet longevity data (shorter-lived cabinets imply less executive dominance), and comparative assessments of legislative independence.
- **Cabinet durability as an indicator:** Countries where cabinets survive longer tend toward executive dominance; countries with frequent cabinet changes (Italy, Finland historically) tend toward greater legislative assertiveness. Lijphart uses average cabinet duration as a partial proxy.
- **The hybrid cases:** Semi-presidential systems (France, Finland) divide executive power between a directly elected president and a cabinet dependent on the legislature, producing variable executive-legislative relations depending on whether the president's party controls the legislature (*cohabitation*).

11 Chapter 8: Electoral Systems: Majority and Plurality Methods Versus Proportional Representation

- **Fourth variable on the executives-parties dimension:** Electoral systems are arguably the most consequential institutional variable in the book—they shape party sys-

tems, cabinet formation, and ultimately most of the other variables on the executives-parties dimension.

- **The majoritarian-PR spectrum:** Lijphart classifies electoral systems along a spectrum from fully majoritarian (single-member plurality, AV, two-round systems) to fully proportional (party-list PR with large district magnitudes). The key metric is **disproportionality**: how much do seat shares deviate from vote shares?
- **Disproportionality as the key measure:** Using the Gallagher index of disproportionality, Lijphart shows that majoritarian systems are highly disproportional (UK, USA, Australia, Canada) while PR systems are close to proportional (Netherlands, Israel). Semi-proportional systems (Germany, Japan's pre-reform mixed system) fall in between.
- **District magnitude as the primary determinant:** The single most important determinant of proportionality is **district magnitude**—the number of seats elected from each district. Single-member districts produce plurality winners; large multi-member districts with proportional allocation produce near-perfect proportionality.
- **Consequences for representation:** PR systems consistently produce more women in parliament, more parties in parliament, and more accurate translation of voter preferences into legislative seats. Majoritarian systems produce clearer majorities but at the cost of significant mis-representation of smaller parties and groups.
- **The reform wave:** Lijphart notes a global trend toward PR or mixed systems over the study period, with New Zealand's 1996 adoption of MMP being the most striking conversion among established democracies.
- **Electoral systems and other variables:** Because electoral systems shape party systems and through them cabinet formation, electoral system choice is in many ways the master variable on the executives-parties dimension—changes in electoral rules tend to cascade through all other variables on the dimension.

12 Chapter 9: Interest Groups: Pluralism Versus Corporatism

- **Fifth variable on the executives-parties dimension:** The organization of interest intermediation—how societal interests are represented and consulted in the policy process—is the final variable on the executives-parties dimension.
- **Pluralism:** In pluralist systems (USA, UK, Canada), many competing interest groups freely compete for access and influence; no group has a privileged or monopolistic relationship with the state; and the government does not formally incorporate interest groups into the policy process. Competition among groups, not coordination with the state, is the dominant mode.

- **Corporatism:** In corporatist systems (Austria, Netherlands, Sweden, Norway), peak associations of labor and capital are granted privileged access to the state in exchange for their ability to discipline their members and deliver compliance with negotiated agreements. The state, labor, and capital engage in structured tripartite bargaining over wages, social policy, and economic management.
- **Corporatism and consensus:** Corporatism is the interest group expression of the consensus principle—instead of leaving interest conflict to competitive markets of influence, corporatism structures it through institutionalized negotiation and compromise. Groups are included in policymaking rather than forced to fight for access.
- **Measurement:** Lijphart draws on existing corporatism indices (Lehmbruch, Schmitter) to classify countries from pluralist to corporatist. The Netherlands, Austria, Switzerland, and Scandinavia score highest on corporatism; the USA, Canada, and Australia score highest on pluralism.
- **Corporatism and economic performance:** The corporatism literature (Katzenstein, Hicks, Kenworthy) has linked corporatist systems to lower strike rates, lower inflation, lower unemployment, and better macroeconomic coordination—providing part of the empirical basis for the consensus democracy performance argument.
- **The fifth variable's coherence:** Corporatism is conceptually distinct from the other four executives-parties variables, but it loads consistently on the same empirical dimension in factor analysis—confirming that interest group organization is part of the same underlying consensus-majoritarian syndrome.

13 Chapter 10: The Executives-Parties Dimension

- **Dimension synthesis:** This chapter brings together the five executives-parties variables—cabinet type, executive-legislative relations, party systems, electoral systems, and interest groups—and demonstrates that they form a coherent empirical dimension.
- **Factor analysis:** Using principal component or factor analysis across the 36 countries, Lijphart shows that the five variables are positively correlated and load on a single underlying factor. Countries that score toward the consensus pole on one variable tend to score similarly on the others.
- **The composite index:** Lijphart constructs an **executives-parties index** by standardizing and averaging the five variables, positioning each country along the majoritarian-consensus spectrum. The Netherlands and Switzerland score toward the consensus pole; the UK and New Zealand score toward the majoritarian pole.
- **The coherence of the Westminster syndrome:** The correlation among variables confirms that the Westminster model is a syndrome, not an accident—majoritarian electoral systems generate two-party systems, which generate single-party majority cabinets, which

generate executive dominance. The variables reinforce each other institutionally.

- **The coherence of the consensus syndrome:** Similarly, PR electoral systems generate multiparty systems, which require coalition cabinets, which reduce executive dominance, and tend to be paired with corporatist interest intermediation. The consensus variables also reinforce each other.
- **Outliers and hybrid cases:** Some countries do not fit neatly on the dimension (Japan, France, India). Lijphart discusses these cases as partially reflecting institutional features that do not map cleanly onto the majoritarian-consensus spectrum, and partially reflecting the imperfection of any empirical operationalization.
- **The dimension as a design choice:** The executives-parties dimension represents a genuine political choice that countries and constitutional designers make, not an inevitable outcome of social structure. This is crucial to the book's normative argument: if institutional patterns are choices, they can be changed.

14 Chapter 11: Federal and Unitary Systems

- **First variable on the federal-unitary dimension:** The degree of federalism and decentralization is the first variable on the second major dimension. Federal systems disperse power territorially; unitary systems concentrate it in the central government.
- **A spectrum, not a binary:** Lijphart treats federalism as a continuous variable rather than a dichotomy. Countries range from purely unitary (New Zealand, the UK until devolution) through centralized federations (Australia) to highly decentralized federations (Switzerland, the USA, Germany).
- **Measurement:** The measure combines formal constitutional federalism with fiscal and administrative decentralization—the share of sub-national government in total government expenditure and employment. Formal federal structures without real fiscal autonomy are coded toward the unitary pole.
- **Federalism as a veto point:** Federal systems create multiple decision centers that can block or delay central government action. This is the federal-unitary dimension's expression of the consensus principle: territorial dispersion of power constrains majority rule in the same way that coalition cabinets and PR constrain it on the executives-parties dimension.
- **Federalism and social heterogeneity:** Federal arrangements are more common in large, territorially diverse, or culturally heterogeneous countries—where territorial units map onto distinct communities. Switzerland, Belgium, Canada, and India all use federal arrangements partly to manage territorial or linguistic cleavages.
- **The US hybrid:** The United States is a strong federation on this dimension despite being majoritarian on the executives-parties dimension, illustrating that the two dimensions are

genuinely orthogonal rather than correlated.

- **Devolution and quasi-federalism:** Some formally unitary systems (UK post-1997, Spain with its autonomous communities) have undergone significant devolution, moving toward the middle of the dimension without adopting formal federalism. Lijphart’s historical coding captures the pre-devolution period for most of these cases.

15 Chapter 12: Concentrated Versus Divided Legislative Power

- **Second variable on the federal-unitary dimension:** The structure of the legislature—unicameral vs. bicameral, and the relative power of the two chambers in bicameral systems—is the second variable on this dimension.
- **A typology of bicameralism:** Lijphart distinguishes: (1) **unicameralism** (New Zealand, Denmark, Finland, Israel, Greece—concentrating legislative power); (2) **weak or insignificant bicameralism** (UK House of Lords, Canadian Senate—formally bicameral but one chamber has little real power); (3) **significant or “congruent” bicameralism** (two chambers with comparable power but similar composition); and (4) **strong and “incongruent” bicameralism** (two chambers with comparable power and different compositions—USA, Germany, Switzerland, Australia).
- **Strong bicameralism as a veto point:** When both chambers have substantial power and are constituted differently (one by population, one by territorial unit), bicameralism creates a genuine additional veto point—legislation must satisfy two differently constituted majorities. This is the strongest form of bicameralism and the most clearly aligned with the consensus principle.
- **The German Bundesrat:** Germany’s upper chamber represents the *Länder* governments, not the population; it has strong powers over legislation affecting the states. This makes Germany’s bicameralism both strong and incongruent, placing it toward the consensus pole on this variable.
- **The US Senate:** The US Senate has equal representation across states regardless of population, combined with filibuster rules requiring supermajorities for many legislation; this makes it one of the world’s strongest and most incongruent upper chambers.
- **Unicameralism and the Westminster model:** Westminster-influenced democracies (New Zealand, Caribbean states) often adopt unicameral legislatures as the logical institutional expression of the majority-rule principle—a single popularly elected chamber can act decisively without interchamberal conflict.
- **Connection to federalism:** Strong and incongruent bicameralism is closely associated with federalism—federal systems typically give territorial units representation in an upper

chamber. The correlation between federalism and strong bicameralism helps explain the empirical coherence of the federal-unitary dimension.

16 Chapter 13: Constitutions and Constitutional Amendment

- **Third variable on the federal-unitary dimension:** The rigidity or flexibility of the constitution is the third variable. Rigid constitutions entrench constraints on majority rule; flexible constitutions (or no written constitution at all) leave the legislature free to change fundamental rules.
- **Defining rigidity:** Constitutional rigidity is measured by the procedural difficulty of formal constitutional amendment—the supermajorities required, the number of veto actors whose consent is necessary, and whether popular referendums are required.
- **The spectrum:** At one extreme, the UK operates without a written constitution—Parliament can change any rule by simple majority at any time (maximum flexibility). At the other extreme, the US Constitution requires two-thirds majorities in both chambers of Congress and ratification by three-quarters of state legislatures (maximum rigidity).
- **Entrenchment as a constraint on majority rule:** Rigid constitutions protect minority rights and fundamental institutional arrangements from simple-majority revision—a core expression of the consensus principle. They prevent a temporary majority from unilaterally rewriting the rules to advantage themselves permanently.
- **Constitutional rigidity and political stability:** The relationship between rigidity and stability is complex. Very rigid constitutions may impede necessary adaptation; very flexible ones allow temporary majorities to entrench themselves or undermine minority rights. The optimal level of rigidity is contested.
- **The UK as the limiting flexible case:** The absence of a written UK constitution is the most striking instance of constitutional flexibility in the sample; it allows parliamentary sovereignty to operate without formal constitutional constraint, which is both a Westminster strength (decisive governance) and a vulnerability (minority rights depend on political culture, not legal entrenchment).
- **Codified versus uncoded constitutions:** Lijphart notes that the distinction between written and unwritten constitutions does not map perfectly onto flexibility—some countries with written constitutions can amend them easily, while some aspects of the UK's unwritten constitution are practically very resistant to change.

17 Chapter 14: Judicial Review and Central Bank Independence

- **Fourth and fifth variables on the federal-unitary dimension:** The existence and strength of judicial review of legislation, and the independence of the central bank from political control, are the final two variables on the federal-unitary dimension.
- **Judicial review:** Where courts can strike down legislation as unconstitutional, they add another veto point constraining majority action. Strong judicial review (USA, Germany, India) protects constitutional rules and minority rights from legislative override; the absence of judicial review (UK pre-Human Rights Act, Netherlands) concentrates final authority in the legislature.
- **Constitutional courts versus supreme courts:** Some countries have specialized constitutional courts (Germany's Bundesverfassungsgericht, France's Conseil Constitutionnel) empowered to review legislation for constitutional compliance; others vest judicial review in the general supreme court (USA). Both qualify as judicial review systems; the absence of any form of constitutional judicial control is the unitary/majoritarian pole.
- **Central bank independence:** An independent central bank removes monetary policy from direct political control, imposing a non-majoritarian constraint on economic governance. Highly independent central banks (Bundesbank, Federal Reserve, Swiss National Bank) cannot be instructed by elected governments; politically dependent banks can be directed to accommodate fiscal policy.
- **Measurement of central bank independence:** Lijphart draws on the Alesina-Summers and Cukierman indices, which rate central banks on formal legal independence, governor tenure, and policy mandate. The Bundesbank and Swiss National Bank score highest; many smaller or developing democracies score lowest.
- **Both as non-majoritarian constraints:** Both judicial review and central bank independence share a common logic—they remove important policy domains from direct majority-rule control, placing authority in expert or judicial bodies insulated from electoral pressure. This is a form of consensus (or rather counter-majoritarian) constraint.
- **The coherence of the fifth variable:** Central bank independence is perhaps the most unusual of the ten variables, sitting at the intersection of institutional design and economic policy. Its inclusion is justified by the same logic as the others: it creates an additional constraint on majority action and disperses effective governing power.

18 Chapter 15: The Federal-Unitary Dimension

- **Dimension synthesis:** This chapter brings together the five federal-unitary variables—federalism, bicameralism, constitutional rigidity, judicial review, and central bank independence—

and demonstrates that they form a coherent empirical dimension, as the executives-parties variables did.

- **Factor analysis:** Lijphart again shows that the five variables are positively correlated across the 36 countries and load on a single underlying factor—countries that score federalist on one variable tend to score similarly on the others.
- **The composite index:** Averaging the five standardized variables produces a **federal-unitary index** that positions countries along the unitary-federal spectrum. The USA and Switzerland score toward the federal-consensus pole; New Zealand and the UK score toward the unitary-majoritarian pole.
- **The US paradox resolved:** The United States' position becomes clear when the two dimensions are separated—the US is majoritarian on the executives-parties dimension but strongly federal-consensus on the federal-unitary dimension. This explains why the US looks like neither a pure Westminster nor a pure consensus system.
- **Orthogonality of the two dimensions:** The two dimensions are empirically largely uncorrelated across the 36 countries. Knowing a country's score on the executives-parties dimension tells you relatively little about its federal-unitary score, confirming that the two dimensions capture distinct phenomena.
- **Institutional reinforcement within each dimension:** Within each dimension, variables tend to reinforce each other historically—federal systems tend to develop strong bicameralism and rigid constitutions because the same political dynamics that produce federalism also produce other veto points. This is path-dependent institutional co-evolution, not mere correlation.
- **Implications for reform:** The separability of the two dimensions implies that countries can reform on one dimension while leaving the other intact—for example, adopting PR without changing their federal structure, or increasing central bank independence without altering their party system.

19 Chapter 16: The Two-Dimensional Conceptual Map of Democracy

- **The full map:** This chapter presents the book's central analytical contribution—a two-dimensional scatterplot in which each of the 36 democracies is positioned according to its score on both the executives-parties dimension (horizontal axis) and the federal-unitary dimension (vertical axis).
- **Four quadrants:** The two-dimensional map produces four empirical clusters:
 - **Majoritarian-unitary** (Westminster quadrant): UK, New Zealand, Barbados, Bahamas—majoritarian on both dimensions.

- **Consensus-unitary**: Netherlands, Belgium, Sweden, Norway, Denmark—consensual executives-parties dimension combined with unitary government.
 - **Majoritarian-federal** (US quadrant): USA, Canada, Australia—majoritarian executives-parties combined with federal structures.
 - **Consensus-federal**: Switzerland, Germany—consensual on both dimensions.
- **No pure consensus archetype**: Unlike the Westminster model (which the UK exemplifies closely), there is no single country that exemplifies the consensus model on both dimensions—Switzerland is the closest but has somewhat majoritarian features in some respects.
 - **The meaning of orthogonality**: The fact that countries cluster in all four quadrants, rather than along a single diagonal, confirms that the two dimensions are genuinely independent design choices. Societies can mix majoritarianism on one dimension with consensus on the other.
 - **Explaining the pattern**: The clustering in the upper-left quadrant (consensus-unitary) reflects the prevalence of unitary Nordic and Low Countries democracies with PR and coalition governments. The lower-right quadrant (majoritarian-federal) reflects the diffusion of Westminster institutions into large, diverse former British colonies.
 - **The map as a research tool**: The two-dimensional map provides a richer classification of democracies than any single variable or one-dimensional ranking. It allows researchers to test whether institutional features (not just the majoritarian-consensus composite) explain policy outcomes.

20 Chapter 17: Macroeconomic Management and the Control of Violence

- **The performance question**: This chapter begins the book’s systematic analysis of whether institutional design affects policy outcomes. Lijphart tests whether consensus democracies outperform majoritarian ones on macroeconomic performance and control of political violence.
- **Macroeconomic performance variables**: Lijphart examines economic growth rates, inflation rates, unemployment rates, and budget surplus/deficit ratios across the 36 countries over the study period. These are the standard indicators of macroeconomic management quality.
- **Null result for growth**: Consensus democracies do not have significantly higher or lower economic growth rates than majoritarian ones. This is a crucial finding—it means that adopting consensus institutions does not impose an economic growth penalty, undermining the common argument that consensus democracy sacrifices efficiency for inclusion.

- **Better inflation and unemployment performance in consensus systems:** Countries with corporatist interest group systems (part of the executives-parties consensus dimension) tend to have better combined inflation-unemployment performance (lower “Okun’s misery index”), consistent with the broader corporatism literature.
- **Political violence:** Lijphart examines political riots, deaths from political violence, and related indicators. Consensus democracies show lower levels of political violence on average, consistent with the theory that power-sharing reduces the stakes of political conflict and therefore the motivation for political violence.
- **Controlling for confounders:** Lijphart controls for GDP per capita, country size, and region in most analyses. The institutional effects tend to persist after controls, though the statistical significance varies by specification.
- **The key negative finding:** The absence of a growth penalty in consensus systems is normatively crucial. The main objection to consensus democracy—that it sacrifices economic efficiency for political inclusion—is not supported by the cross-national evidence. This shifts the burden of argument toward defenders of majoritarian institutions.

21 Chapter 18: Democracies’ Policy Performance: Conclusions

- **Comprehensive performance analysis:** The final performance chapter extends the analysis to a wider range of policy outcomes—women’s representation, social expenditure, environmental protection, foreign aid generosity, incarceration rates, and subjective measures of democratic quality.
- **Women’s representation:** PR systems consistently elect significantly more women to parliament than majoritarian systems. The mechanism is structural: PR systems use party lists, which create opportunities for parties to achieve gender balance; plurality systems with single-member districts produce strong incumbency advantages that disadvantage new entrants including women.
- **Social welfare performance:** Consensus democracies spend more on social protection—welfare, health, education—as a share of GDP, even controlling for economic development. The broader coalitions that characterize consensus government tend to include parties representing a wider range of social groups, producing more universalist social policy.
- **Environmental performance:** Countries with consensus institutions tend to perform better on environmental indicators and sign more international environmental agreements. Lijphart attributes this partly to proportional representation, which gives green parties legislative presence that influences mainstream parties.
- **Foreign aid:** Consensus democracies tend to spend more on foreign aid as a share of

GNP. Lijphart argues this reflects the “kinder, gentler” quality of consensus governance—a broader coalition of groups with humanitarian interests shapes foreign policy.

- **Incarceration rates:** Majoritarian democracies incarcerate at significantly higher rates than consensus democracies. The USA is the extreme case; Nordic consensus democracies have among the lowest incarceration rates in the world. Lijphart interprets this as evidence of the “kinder, gentler” thesis—consensus institutions produce less punitive policy responses.
- **Quality of democracy:** Consensus democracies score higher on cross-national measures of democratic quality, including voter turnout, political rights, and citizen satisfaction. PR-based systems in particular have higher voter participation, as the proportionality of the electoral system makes votes feel more consequential.
- **The normative conclusion:** The evidence consistently favors the consensus model on quality-of-democracy and “kinder, gentler” performance measures, while showing no disadvantage on economic growth. Lijphart concludes that consensus democracy is not merely equally good as majoritarian democracy—it is demonstrably superior by most measurable criteria relevant to democratic theory.
- **Implications for institutional design:** The book’s findings support the case for PR electoral systems, coalition government, corporatism, federalism, and strong constitutional constraints as institutional choices that improve democratic performance. This is an explicit policy recommendation, not merely a descriptive finding.
- **Applicability to new democracies:** Lijphart argues the findings are particularly relevant for countries designing or redesigning democratic institutions—including post-conflict societies and democratizing states—where the choice between majoritarian and consensus design is genuinely open.